NCE EXAM PREP

Practice Exam 01

Domain 1

Professional Development & Counselor Self-Awareness

25 Practice Questions | 33 minutes

A, B, C answer choices

Answer Key and Explanations included

> **Instructions.** Select the single best answer for each question. Record your answers separately. This domain practice set is drawn from Full-Length Practice Exam 01. Use the suggested 33-minute practice timer. Do not consult Part B until you complete Part A. These domain timings are editorial practice allocations, not official NBCC section limits.

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PART A — QUESTIONS

Choose one answer (A, B, or C) per question.

Question 1

> A newly licensed counselor in a community clinic has general experience treating anxiety but has never delivered exposure and response prevention. A client with obsessive-compulsive disorder wants to begin this treatment, and the clinic can provide an experienced supervisor.

Which professional development step is most appropriate before the counselor delivers the treatment?

A) Attend a brief overview webinar and begin the protocol independently

B) Arrange clinical supervision while obtaining structured training in the treatment

C) Ask an experienced colleague for a one-time opinion and then use the full protocol

Question 2

> A university counselor is trained to administer and interpret brief symptom screeners. The disability services office asks the counselor to conduct a comprehensive neuropsychological battery for a student's accommodation request. The counselor has never used the battery.

What should the counselor do?

A) Learn the battery from its manual and administer it because the purpose is educational

B) Administer the battery but ask a qualified evaluator to confirm only the final diagnosis

C) Limit services to assessments within current competence and arrange consultation or referral to a qualified evaluator

Question 3

> A community agency begins serving more Deaf clients. A counselor knows conversational American Sign Language but is not fluent in clinical communication. One new client requests a qualified interpreter and wants to remain at the agency.

Which action best supports professional development and equitable access?

A) Arrange qualified language access, learn effective interpreter collaboration, and avoid presenting conversational skill as clinical fluency

B) Ask the client to bring a family member while the counselor improves sign-language skills through practice

C) Refer all Deaf clients to another agency until the counselor becomes clinically fluent in American Sign Language

Question 4

A counselor in a rural clinic has general experience with adolescents but limited training in eating disorders. A 16-year-old reports restrictive eating, recent fainting, and rapid weight loss. The nearest specialty program can provide medical and behavioral evaluation by telehealth and a regional partner.

Which response best reflects awareness of professional limitations?

A) Begin weekly general counseling and reconsider referral only if eating behavior does not improve

B) Facilitate prompt specialized and medical evaluation and participate in ongoing care only within demonstrated competence

C) Terminate all involvement because any continuing role would exceed the counselor's competence

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Question 5

A counselor plans to expand telehealth services across state lines and learns that requirements and professional guidance have recently changed. The counselor wants continuing education that is accurate and relevant.

How should the counselor select the learning resources?

A) Choose the highest-rated commercial course because participant ratings demonstrate legal accuracy

B) Use the counselor's current state's rules because professional standards are uniform across states

C) Verify current requirements with authoritative jurisdictional and professional sources, then select training that addresses those requirements

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Question 6

A school counselor reviews program data and finds that multilingual students with grades comparable to their peers are referred to advanced courses at a much lower rate. Current referrals depend heavily on informal teacher recommendations.

Which response best combines professional development with advocacy for cross-cultural fairness?

A) Encourage multilingual students to request advanced courses without changing the referral process

B) Offer study-skills workshops to multilingual students who were not referred

C) Study culturally responsive identification practices, examine referral criteria with the school team, and advocate for a transparent process

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Question 7

> A counselor notices feeling defensive during sessions with clients who communicate assertively. The counselor suspects that this reaction may be influencing which topics are explored but cannot yet identify a consistent pattern.

Which reflective practice would be most useful?

A) Ask assertive clients whether they think the counselor is competent after each difficult exchange

B) Track triggers, internal reactions, interventions, and client responses in a structured reflection and review patterns in supervision

C) Avoid working with assertive clients until the counselor no longer experiences discomfort

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Question 8

> In an integrated care clinic, a counselor experienced in brief cognitive behavioral interventions meets an older adult with severe dissociation and a complex trauma history. The client requests specialized trauma treatment that the counselor has not been trained to provide.

Which response best addresses counselor-client fit?

A) Explain the limitation, coordinate referral to a qualified trauma clinician, and offer interim support within the counselor's competence

B) Continue brief cognitive behavioral work because a strong alliance can compensate for limited trauma training

C) Give the client a specialist's telephone number and discontinue contact without discussing continuity of care

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Question 9

> During an intake, a client says, "I am not sure someone from your background will understand what my family expects of me." The counselor feels defensive and is tempted to list prior work with people from the client's community.

What is the most appropriate self-aware response?

A) Reassure the client by describing the counselor's experience with similar cultural groups

B) Redirect to symptoms because discussing cultural differences may weaken the counseling alliance

C) Acknowledge the concern, invite the client to describe what understanding would look like, and discuss preferences and options

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Question 10

Which set of resources generally provides the strongest foundation for learning about an emerging counseling intervention?

A) Current practice guidelines, peer-reviewed research, and training led by qualified professionals

B) Popular social media discussions, client testimonials, and a widely followed influencer's course

C) Vendor-sponsored case examples, promotional outcome summaries, and informal peer enthusiasm

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Question 11

> After several months with an unusually high caseload, a counselor is sleeping poorly, becoming irritable with coworkers, and discovering omissions in recent progress notes. No client emergency is currently known.

What is the best response?

A) Promptly address workload and care quality with a supervisor, correct affected records, and establish sustainable supports and recovery practices

B) Schedule a vacation several months away and maintain the current workload until then

C) Work longer hours to eliminate the backlog before telling anyone about the strain

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Question 12

> A client's grief resembles a counselor's unresolved experience after a parent's death. The counselor notices an urge to protect the client from painful topics and has repeatedly redirected the conversation when the client begins discussing anger toward the deceased parent.

How should the counselor respond to this pattern?

A) Examine the possible countertransference in supervision and monitor how it is shaping interventions

B) Describe the counselor's own loss in detail so the client understands the source of the reactions

C) End counseling immediately because any personal similarity prevents effective work

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Question 13

Which plan most effectively develops competence in an empirically supported counseling approach?

A) Read the treatment manual and use the approach whenever its title matches a client's diagnosis

B) Complete skills-based training, obtain supervised feedback, and monitor client response while consulting current evidence

C) Observe several online demonstrations and rely on clinical intuition to modify the approach

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Question 14

Which statement best distinguishes vicarious trauma from occupational burnout?

A) Vicarious trauma occurs only after direct exposure to danger, whereas burnout occurs after hearing clients' accounts

B) Vicarious trauma can alter beliefs and worldview through empathic exposure, whereas burnout more often reflects chronic occupational strain and exhaustion

C) Vicarious trauma is a temporary loss of motivation, whereas burnout is a diagnosable trauma disorder

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Question 15

A client repeatedly describes the counselor as the only person who truly understands and asks for extra contact between sessions. The counselor enjoys feeling indispensable and has begun allowing this client's sessions to run longer than other clients' sessions.

What should the counselor do?

A) Recognize the reinforcement of the boundary drift, seek supervision, and restore a clinically appropriate structure

B) Continue the longer sessions because the client's positive transference strengthens the alliance

C) Tell the client that the praise is manipulative and prohibit any discussion of the relationship

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Question 16

A client who uses a wheelchair prefers in-person counseling, but the agency's counseling rooms are reached only by stairs. A manager suggests that the counselor simply offer telehealth. The counselor realizes that professional knowledge about disability-responsive practice is limited.

Which action best addresses both professional growth and client advocacy?

A) Explain that telehealth is clinically equivalent and therefore resolves the access concern

B) Advocate for an accessible service option while seeking training and consultation on disability-responsive practice

C) Refer the client to another agency solely because the counselor lacks experience with wheelchair users

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Question 17

A counselor is proficient with depression and anxiety screeners but is asked to add a complex personality inventory to routine intake. The counselor has no training in selecting, administering, scoring, or interpreting that instrument.

How should the counselor respond?

A) Identify the competence gap and obtain appropriate training and consultation or refer that assessment component before using the instrument

B) Administer the inventory because standardized instructions eliminate the need for specialized competence

C) Use the inventory only with clients whose presentations appear straightforward and seek help for unusual profiles

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Question 18

> While reviewing a strained caseload, a counselor realizes that a scheduling error delayed follow-up with a client who recently reported passive suicidal thoughts and completed a safety plan. The counselor does not know the client's current status.

What should the counselor do?

A) Promptly reassess or arrange appropriate contact and coverage, disclose the lapse in supervision, and address the caseload conditions that contributed

B) Begin a personal wellness routine and wait for the client to initiate contact if additional support is needed

C) Transfer the entire caseload immediately because one follow-up error proves the counselor is unfit to practice

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Question 19

> An outpatient practice is considering an artificial intelligence service that creates draft progress notes from recorded sessions. A counselor has not previously studied the professional responsibilities associated with such tools.

Which learning activity would best prepare the counselor to participate in the practice's decision?

A) Complete credible ethics and legal training addressing consent, privacy, data handling, documentation, and applicable jurisdictional requirements

B) Rely on the vendor's product demonstration because it explains the tool's security and accuracy features

C) Delay learning about the tool until the practice adopts it and a client raises a concern

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Question 20

> A counselor is competent in a specialized treatment that a prospective client needs, but the client requires twice-weekly sessions for the next month. The counselor has no openings beyond one appointment every other week.

Which response best reflects an appropriate evaluation of fit?

A) Accept the client because competence with the treatment is more important than session availability

B) Reserve the counselor's infrequent openings and ask the client to wait for the schedule to improve

C) Explain the availability limitation and help the client consider qualified providers who can offer the needed frequency

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Question 21

Which activity best supports continuing competence after initial training in an evidence-supported approach?

A) Repeat the same protocol without modification so fidelity is never affected by client context

B) Count the number of clients treated because experience alone demonstrates continued competence

C) Use deliberate practice, qualified feedback, relevant outcome information, and current evidence to refine implementation

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Question 22

> At the end of counseling, a client offers the counselor a small handmade item that has cultural significance as an expression of gratitude. The counselor feels unusually pleased by the client's admiration and worries that either accepting or declining could affect the client.

What is the most self-aware course of action?

A) Accept the item immediately because declining a culturally meaningful gift would be disrespectful

B) Reflect on the counselor's reaction, explore the gift's meaning with the client, and use consultation and relevant policy to guide a transparent response

C) Decline the item immediately because the power difference makes every client gift inappropriate

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Question 23

> A college counselor who completed an introductory workshop on dialectical behavior therapy wants to start a skills group. The counselor has never led a therapy group or received feedback on group facilitation.

What is the best professional development decision?

A) Start the group because teaching skills requires less competence than providing group counseling

B) Refer all interested students elsewhere because competence in group work cannot be developed on the job

C) Obtain group-specific training and supervision and, if feasible, cofacilitate with a competent group counselor

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Question 24

> A counselor who works with children exposed to violence has begun having intrusive images from clients' stories, feeling emotionally numb at home, and dreading sessions that previously felt manageable. The counselor is still meeting basic job duties.

What is the most appropriate response to these changes?

A) Continue the current caseload until job performance clearly declines

B) Avoid discussing difficult cases outside sessions so the images receive less attention

C) Seek supervision or consultation, assess the impact on care, and develop supports that may include caseload adjustments

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Question 25

Which statement most accurately describes professional consultation?

A) It transfers responsibility for the case to a specialist who directs all subsequent services

B) It provides focused expert input while the counselor retains responsibility for professional decisions

C) It is interchangeable with clinical supervision because both relationships are necessarily evaluative

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PART B — ANSWER KEY AND EXPLANATIONS

Answers match the numbered items in Part A.

Question 1 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Arrange clinical supervision while obtaining structured training in the treatment

Explanation: The counselor has a defined competence gap in a specialized intervention, and ongoing supervision permits skills to be developed with oversight before independent delivery. A brief webinar or one-time peer opinion does not provide enough practice, feedback, or accountability for implementing the full protocol.

Question 2 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Limit services to assessments within current competence and arrange consultation or referral to a qualified evaluator

Explanation: Experience with brief screeners does not transfer automatically to a comprehensive neuropsychological battery. The counselor should recognize the limit and involve a properly qualified evaluator rather than learning a high-stakes assessment solely from a manual or outsourcing only the final conclusion.

Question 3 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Arrange qualified language access, learn effective interpreter collaboration, and avoid presenting conversational skill as clinical fluency

Explanation: The client has identified an access method that supports accurate clinical communication, and the counselor can develop competence in working effectively with that resource. Family interpretation and categorical referral both shift the burden to the client instead of addressing access and the counselor's learning needs.

Question 4 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Facilitate prompt specialized and medical evaluation and participate in ongoing care only within demonstrated competence

Explanation: Fainting and rapid weight loss indicate a need for timely medical and eating-disorder expertise beyond general adolescent counseling. Coordinated referral addresses the limitation while still permitting a bounded role if continuity is useful and the counselor is competent to provide it.

Question 5 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Verify current requirements with authoritative jurisdictional and professional sources, then select training that addresses those requirements

Explanation: The counselor should anchor continuing education in current, authoritative information because telehealth requirements may vary and change. Course ratings and assumptions of nationwide uniformity do not establish that training is accurate for the jurisdictions involved.

Question 6 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Study culturally responsive identification practices, examine referral criteria with the school team, and advocate for a transparent process

Explanation: This response combines relevant learning with a systems-level review of a process producing a disparity. Asking students to overcome an opaque system or offering remediation after exclusion leaves the referral mechanism unexamined.

Question 7 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Track triggers, internal reactions, interventions, and client responses in a structured reflection and review patterns in supervision

Explanation: A structured record links the counselor's internal experience to observable clinical choices and outcomes, making recurring patterns easier to examine. Client reassurance would distort the counseling relationship, while avoidance would prevent learning and may unnecessarily limit practice.

Question 8 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Explain the limitation, coordinate referral to a qualified trauma clinician, and offer interim support within the counselor's competence

Explanation: The requested treatment exceeds the counselor's current training, so transparent referral and continuity planning best fit the client's needs. A good alliance does not replace specialized competence, while an abrupt handoff could unnecessarily disrupt care.

Question 9 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Acknowledge the concern, invite the client to describe what understanding would look like, and discuss preferences and options

Explanation: This response manages defensiveness, centers the client's meaning, and makes room to evaluate fit collaboratively. Listing prior experience risks turning the exchange into a defense of the counselor and may imply that familiarity with some group members guarantees understanding of this client.

Question 10 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Current practice guidelines, peer-reviewed research, and training led by qualified professionals

Explanation: These resources allow the counselor to examine the evidence base, appropriate use, limitations, and skill requirements of an emerging intervention. Popularity, testimonials, sponsorship, and informal enthusiasm are weaker indicators of validity and professional competence.

Question 11 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Promptly address workload and care quality with a supervisor, correct affected records, and establish sustainable supports and recovery practices

Explanation: The symptoms are already affecting documentation and professional functioning, so the response must address both current care quality and the conditions driving the strain. A distant vacation or longer work hours would not adequately manage present risks and may worsen impairment.

Question 12 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Examine the possible countertransference in supervision and monitor how it is shaping interventions

Explanation: The counselor's personal loss appears to be influencing avoidance of clinically relevant material. Reflective supervision can help distinguish the client's needs from the counselor's reactions and support corrective changes without unnecessary self-disclosure or automatic termination.

Question 13 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Complete skills-based training, obtain supervised feedback, and monitor client response while consulting current evidence

Explanation: Competence develops through knowledge, practice, feedback, and evaluation of client response, not through exposure to information alone. A manual or demonstrations can contribute to learning but do not by themselves establish the ability to apply an approach appropriately.

Question 14 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Vicarious trauma can alter beliefs and worldview through empathic exposure, whereas burnout more often reflects chronic occupational strain and exhaustion

Explanation: Vicarious trauma is associated with cumulative empathic engagement with others' trauma and may affect cognitive schemas and worldview. Burnout is more commonly characterized by exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced effectiveness related to chronic work stress; neither distinction depends on the inaccurate absolutes in the other options.

Question 15 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Recognize the reinforcement of the boundary drift, seek supervision, and restore a clinically appropriate structure

Explanation: The counselor's gratification is contributing to unequal and potentially dependency-reinforcing exceptions. Supervision and restored structure address both the counselor's reaction and the relational dynamic without shaming the client or treating idealization as inherently beneficial.

Question 16 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Advocate for an accessible service option while seeking training and consultation on disability-responsive practice

Explanation: The client's preference and the physical barrier call for advocacy rather than treating telehealth as an automatic substitute. Training and consultation can also strengthen the counselor's ability to provide responsive care without assuming that disability itself requires referral.

Question 17 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Identify the competence gap and obtain appropriate training and consultation or refer that assessment component before using the instrument

Explanation: Competence with brief screeners does not establish competence with a complex personality inventory. Standardized directions and apparently straightforward cases do not remove the need for training in selection, administration, scoring, and interpretation.

Question 18 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Promptly reassess or arrange appropriate contact and coverage, disclose the lapse in supervision, and address the caseload conditions that contributed

Explanation: The unknown current status makes timely attention to the client's safety the immediate concern, while supervision and workload changes address professional functioning and recurrence. Wellness efforts alone do not resolve the missed follow-up, and one error does not automatically justify abandoning all clients.

Question 19 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Complete credible ethics and legal training addressing consent, privacy, data handling, documentation, and applicable jurisdictional requirements

Explanation: The counselor needs independent, professionally grounded learning about the responsibilities implicated by an AI documentation tool. A vendor demonstration may inform product use, but it cannot substitute for education on ethical and jurisdiction-specific duties.

Question 20 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Explain the availability limitation and help the client consider qualified providers who can offer the needed frequency

Explanation: Fit includes practical capacity to provide the intensity and continuity a client needs, not only technical competence. Transparent discussion and referral options protect access to timely care better than accepting a schedule that cannot meet the stated need.

Question 21 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Use deliberate practice, qualified feedback, relevant outcome information, and current evidence to refine implementation

Explanation: Continuing competence requires active review of performance and evidence after initial training. Experience alone does not confirm quality, and rigidly ignoring client context can turn fidelity into mechanical or poorly fitted practice.

Question 22 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Reflect on the counselor's reaction, explore the gift's meaning with the client, and use consultation and relevant policy to guide a transparent response

Explanation: The gift has relational and cultural meaning, and the counselor's pleasure in being admired may affect judgment. Reflection, dialogue, and consultation support a contextual response; automatic acceptance or refusal would bypass important factors.

Question 23 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Obtain group-specific training and supervision and, if feasible, cofacilitate with a competent group counselor

Explanation: Knowledge of a treatment model does not establish competence in group process and facilitation. Focused training, supervision, and supported practice address the identified gap while allowing competence to grow responsibly.

Question 24 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Seek supervision or consultation, assess the impact on care, and develop supports that may include caseload adjustments

Explanation: Intrusive imagery, emotional numbing, and increased dread after repeated indirect trauma exposure are warning signs that warrant prompt attention even before basic duties fail. Supervision or consultation can help evaluate effects on clients and guide targeted supports rather than relying only on avoidance or endurance.

Question 25 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: It provides focused expert input while the counselor retains responsibility for professional decisions

Explanation: Consultation typically offers specialized guidance without creating the ongoing evaluative authority associated with clinical supervision. The counselor remains accountable for deciding how to use the consultant's input and for the services provided.
